Neal T. Gillespie

Austin, TX 78729 • nealtgill@gmail.com • (513) 807-1705 • LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/neal01

October 19, 2026

Hiring Committee
Irving Public Library
City of Irving
825 W. Irving Blvd, Irving, TX 75060

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Assistant position with the Irving Public Library. I have spent the last four years in nonprofit development, and the part of that work I kept gravitating toward was the collection itself: taking material in, organizing it so it can be found again, and getting it into the hands of the person who needs it. I am now moving toward library work in earnest.

My current title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the materials I manage are printed fundraising pieces. That means direct mail letters and their reply devices, printed proposals and reports prepared for major donors, inserts, newsletters, and the other physical outreach a development office puts in the mail. Every piece we produce ends up in a physical archive that I oversee. I take the samples in when they come back from the printer, sort and label them, shelve them by campaign and mail code, and pull them when a writer or a director needs a past piece to work from. It is a working collection that people retrieve from constantly, not a storage closet.

When I took it over, nothing in that archive could be found without asking me, so I built the system that fixed it. I designed a SQL database for the collection, defined a consistent record for every piece covering mail code, campaign, date, format, audience and vendor, and then worked back through several campaign years of material to catalog it against that standard. On top of the database I built a searchable reading room, so staff can query the collection themselves, narrow it by any of those fields, view the scanned copy, and find where the physical original sits on the shelf. I maintain both, train new staff on them, and troubleshoot for people who get stuck. Nothing has taught me more about why consistent cataloging actually matters.

Before that I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. The university was assembling a small library largely from donated books, and I handled the intake side of it: receiving collections as they arrived, documenting what was in them, processing them onto the shelves, and recording the gift. The one I remember best was a complete set of the *Harvard Classics*. I was also the person who walked visitors through that library and answered their questions about the collection. That is the work that turned a general interest in libraries into wanting to do this for a living.

Earlier, as a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law, I staffed the service window as the first person students talked to. I registered and verified records, explained procedures that were not obvious, made referrals, and processed more than five hundred transcripts and exam records in PeopleSoft at a high standard of accuracy. Checking materials in and out, shelving accurately, helping someone at a desk who is not sure what they need, and keeping records clean enough to trust are all things I have done daily, just not yet inside a public library. I am comfortable with the physical side of the work and with the schedule, including evenings and weekends and the thousand hour annual maximum.

I am building toward this as a career rather than trying it out. I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and start a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. I also founded the Free Knowledge Library, an archive cataloging political literature, where I designed the classification scheme and built the catalog myself.

Thank you for your consideration. I would welcome the chance to talk about the role.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie